# AN ENGLISHMAN AT THE MUGHAL COURT

In the early 1600s, in Allahabad, Salim found himself surrounded once again by his easily complicit companions. Crumbling under the strain of the ongoing tussle with his father, the prince became erratic and volatile. Already addicted to wine, Salim now added opium to the mix when he found the intoxication of alcohol insufficient. Under the influence of these intoxicants Salim's behaviour, ever unpredictable, now descended into sadism. In one particularly horrific incident, a writer of Salim's developed an infatuation for one of the pages at court who, in turn, was smitten with a third servant. The three young men, hoping to find a more clement atmosphere at Daniyal's court, fled to the Deccan. When Salim heard of this, he became enraged, his anger no doubt exacerbated by mention of his brother Daniyal, who was now a hated rival for the throne. He had the men captured and brought to court where the writer was skinned alive in his presence, one servant was castrated, while the third young man was subjected to lashes.

When he heard of this grotesque incident, Akbar said, 'We have conquered a whole world by the sword, but until today we have not ordered so much as a sheep to be skinned in our presence. My son is unimaginably hard-hearted if he can have a man skinned in his presence.' But Akbar too was not altogether immune from violent anger at this time of enormous uncertainty and tension. On one occasion Akbar emerged from his chambers after evening prayer earlier than was his wont. He walked into the diwan-e-aam to find all the servants missing except for one unfortunate lamplighter who was curled up, asleep, next to the Padshah's throne. Furious at this dereliction of duty, Akbar had the lamplighter thrown from the tower of the palace where he 'was dashed into a thousand pieces'. Still fuming with anger, Akbar severely reprimanded the officer whose watch it was and the other officers on guard. Tellingly, Akbar sarcastically ordered them to join Salim's camp instead of remaining at Agra. It appeared that under the strain of this succession drama, even Akbar's iron self-control was cracking.